particular interest. When these early stages are strong, there is a possibility of making significant progress in actually doing reforms. The leadership which finds itself in such a situation should thank the people who put in the requisite investments, in previous years, to build the early stages.

When these early stages are weak, there is little opportunity to achieve significant reforms. It is quite inexpensive, to nurture these stages of the pipeline, and create reform opportunities for the future. But when a leadership is short-sighted and skimps on this nurturing, this has harmful effects in ways that are not visible at the time.

Summing up

Progress in policy involves a pipeline that runs from data to research to multiple policy proposals to public debate about rival proposals to decisions to legal instruments to implementation. If we use the key '|' to denote a pipe then the policy pipeline is data | research | proposals | debate | decisions | legal instruments | implementation. This is a slow, siege-style assault.

There is a widespread beliefs that crises are an ideal opportunity for reforms. However, crises are difficult times. If the pipeline is not mature, ahead of time, in the heat of the crisis it is not possible to overcome the gaps in knowledge and human capacity. When crises enlarge the range of possibilities, this includes some harmful ideas. Checks and balances are less effective in a crisis. Things can more easily go wrong. Institutions that are weak in normal times are unable to deal with the day-to-day events of a crisis. We should dread a crisis.

For a given field (e.g., property rights), it is useful to formally assess the state of capability in each stage of the policy pipeline. Each stage requires mature knowledge and a strong community. This will help guide the most valuable subsequent actions that need to be undertaken to obtain reform in a field.